SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #46 · PROSPERITY AND BLESSING

“Wealth proves God is pleased with me.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

When things go well, it is natural to give thanks. The danger is concluding that success is God’s stamp of approval. Teaching that links faithfulness with financial reward can lead us to read our bank balance as a spiritual report card, and to look down on those who have less.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus said, “Watch out! Guard yourselves against every form of greed, for one’s life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions.” Paul tells the rich not to be conceited or to put their hope in the uncertainty of wealth, but in God. Proverbs warns that he who trusts in his riches will fall. Jesus said it is easier for a camel to pass through the eye of a needle than for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God. Wealth can be a gift, but it is not a sign of God’s favor.

> *“And He said to them, ‘Watch out! Guard yourselves against every form of greed, for one’s life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions.’”* (Luke 12:15).

Also see

> “Instruct those who are rich in the present age not to be conceited and not to put their hope in the uncertainty of wealth, but in God, who richly provides all things for us to enjoy” (1 Timothy 6:17).

> “Again I tell you, it is easier for a camel to pass through the eye of a needle than for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God” (Matthew 19:24).

> “He who trusts in his riches will fall, but the righteous will thrive like foliage” (Proverbs 11:28).

> “Keep your lives free from the love of money and be content with what you have, for God has said: ‘Never will I leave you, never will I forsake you.’” (Hebrews 13:5).

Common self-statements

- God is blessing me because I am doing right.
- My success shows I am in His favor.
- People who struggle must be doing something wrong.
- I deserve what I have.
- If I lose this, God must be displeased.
- My wealth is my reward.

Common logical errors

- Just-world thinking: Believing that people always get what they deserve.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling blessed and concluding that wealth means approval.
- Halo effect: Assuming prosperity proves character.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing wealth as proof and poverty as failure.

Challenging questions

- Where did I learn that wealth means God’s approval?
- Do I know people who are faithful and not wealthy, or wealthy and not faithful?

- How did Jesus and the apostles live?
- What does Jesus say about trusting in riches?
- What would I conclude about God's pleasure if I lost my money?
- How can I hold wealth with thanks and openness?

Truth summary

> God is pleased with me because of Christ, not because of my balance. Wealth is a gift to steward and share, not a measure of His approval. I can give thanks without judging myself or others by money.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Riches, Beware of
- Riches, True
- Pride
- Humility
- Giving

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Money/Riches
- Pride

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ's final restoration.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Forever — Kari Jobe
Christ's resurrection grounds hope in His victory over sin and death.

How Great Thou Art — Jordan Smith
This classic hymn connects God's greatness, Christ's sacrifice, and future hope.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Wealth proves God is pleased with me"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Wealth proves God is pleased with me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Where did I learn wealth means approval?
- ☐ What do I trust in?
- ☐ What non-money blessings do I have?
- ☐ How do I view people with less?
- ☐ What could I share?
- ☐ What if I lost it all?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God's approval does not come from wealth.
- ☐ Life is more than possessions.
- ☐ My hope is in God, not riches.
- ☐ Wealth is a gift to share.
- ☐ Others' struggles are not proof of their failure.
- ☐ I am pleasing to Him in Christ.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Luke 12:15**
  "And He said to them, 'Watch out! Guard yourselves against every form of greed, for one's life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions.'"
- ☐ **1 Timothy 6:17**
  "Instruct those who are rich in the present age not to be conceited and not to put their hope in the uncertainty of wealth, but in God, who richly provides all things for us to enjoy."
- ☐ **Proverbs 11:28**
  "He who trusts in his riches will fall, but the righteous will thrive like foliage."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Gift, not grade: Each week, write one thing you have and how you can share or steward it.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Luke 12:15 becomes: "Sarah can write: "My life does not consist of my possessions, so wealth is not proof of God's favor.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Riches, Beware of" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- ☐ Examine the belief. Write where you learned that wealth equals blessing.
- ☐ List non-money blessings. Name ten gifts from God that are not financial.
- ☐ Share something. Give time, money, or help to someone this week.
- ☐ Pray 1 Timothy 6:17. Ask God to keep your hope in Him.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Wealth proves God is pleased with me": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A gift shared
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Wealth proves God is pleased with me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You for what You have given me. Keep me from reading my wealth as Your approval. Help me trust You, share generously, and love people regardless of what they have. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #47 · PROSPERITY AND BLESSING

“If I had enough faith, I wouldn't be poor.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Messages that promise wealth to the faithful are common in some preaching, books, and broadcasts. When someone who prays and gives still struggles, the teaching leaves only one conclusion: my faith must be lacking. Guilt follows, and the pain of poverty is joined by spiritual shame.

What Scripture teaches

James writes, “Has not God chosen the poor of this world to be rich in faith and to inherit the kingdom He promised those who love Him?” Paul describes the Macedonian churches: “In the terrible ordeal they suffered, their abundant joy and deep poverty overflowed into rich generosity.” Paul also says, “I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound… to having plenty and having need.” The heroes of faith were not always rich. Faith is trust in God, not a payment method for a comfortable life.

> *“Listen, my beloved brothers: Has not God chosen the poor of this world to be rich in faith and to inherit the kingdom He promised those who love Him?”* (James 2:5).

Also see

> “In the terrible ordeal they suffered, their abundant joy and deep poverty overflowed into rich generosity” (2 Corinthians 8:2).

> “I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound. I am accustomed to any and every situation—to being filled and being hungry, to having plenty and having need” (Philippians 4:12).

> “Saying: ‘Naked I came from my mother’s womb, and naked I will return. The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away. Blessed be the name of the LORD.’” (Job 1:21).

> “Though the fig tree does not bud and no fruit is on the vines, though the olive crop fails and the fields produce no food, though the sheep are cut off from the fold and no cattle are in the stalls, yet I will exult in the LORD; I will rejoice in the God of my salvation!” (Habakkuk 3:17–18).

Common self-statements

- My faith must be weak.
- If I believed more, God would provide.
- I am not praying hard enough.
- I must be doing something wrong.
- Other believers have more because they have more faith.
- My poverty is my fault spiritually.

Common logical errors

- Personalization: Blaming my faith for circumstances with many causes.
- Magical thinking: Believing faith works like a formula for money.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing faith as either producing wealth or failing.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding my faith is lacking.

Challenging questions

- Who taught me that faith produces wealth?
- Which people in the Bible had great faith and little money?
- What did Paul say about learning to be content in every situation?
- What is faith in Scripture really about?
- What other causes could contribute to my financial situation?
- What would it look like to trust God in this, without guilt?

Truth summary

> Faith is trusting God, not purchasing wealth. Many faithful people in Scripture knew need. My struggle is not proof of weak faith, and I can keep trusting God with joy and sensible steps.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Faith
- Unbelief
- Poverty
- Doubt
- Trust

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Trouble/Hardship
- Money/Riches

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Even If — MercyMe
Trust in God need not depend on receiving the particular miracle we want.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ's resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I had enough faith, I wouldn't be poor"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I had enough faith, I wouldn't be poor." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me faith produces wealth?
- ☐ Who in Scripture trusted God in need?
- ☐ What is faith really?
- ☐ What other causes affect my finances?
- ☐ What practical step can I take?
- ☐ How can I trust God today?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Faith is not a formula for wealth.
- ☐ God chose the poor to be rich in faith.
- ☐ Paul learned to live in plenty and in need.
- ☐ My poverty is not a spiritual failure.
- ☐ I can trust God in every circumstance.
- ☐ God is with me when the fields are empty.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **James 2:5**
  "Listen, my beloved brothers: Has not God chosen the poor of this world to be rich in faith and to inherit the kingdom He promised those who love Him?"
- ☐ **Philippians 4:12**
  "I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound. I am accustomed to any and every situation—to being filled and being hungry, to having plenty and having need."
- ☐ **Habakkuk 3:17–18**
  "Though the fig tree does not bud and no fruit is on the vines, though the olive crop fails and the fields produce no food, though the sheep are cut off from the fold and no cattle are in the stalls, yet I will exult in the LORD; I will rejoice in the God of my salvation!"

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Faith in the middle: Each week, write one way you trusted God this week, whatever your circumstances.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, James 2:5 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God has chosen the poor to be rich in faith, so my need is not proof my faith is weak.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Faith" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- ☐ List faithful people with little. Write names from Scripture or your life who trusted God in need.
- ☐ Replace the guilt. Write a sentence that says what faith really is.
- ☐ Make a plan. Write one practical step you can take about your finances.
- ☐ Read Habakkuk 3:17–18. Pray it as your own.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I had enough faith, I wouldn't be poor": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Trust in the middle
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I had enough faith, I wouldn't be poor.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have wondered if my faith is not enough. Teach me what real faith is. Help me trust You in plenty and in need, and release the guilt that is not from You. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #48 · PROSPERITY AND BLESSING

“Being poor means God has rejected me.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

In many cultures, poverty carries stigma, and that stigma can seep into our view of God. If we have been rejected by people, treated as less, or overlooked at church because of money, it is a short step to feeling that God has turned away from us too.

What Scripture teaches

The psalmist says, “This poor man called out, and the LORD heard him; He saved him from all his troubles.” He prays, “I am poor and needy; may the Lord think of me. You are my helper and deliverer.” God “raises the poor from the dust and lifts the needy from the dump.” Jesus began His ministry saying the Spirit anointed Him to preach good news to the poor. Proverbs says, “The rich and the poor have this in common: The LORD is Maker of them all.” God does not reject the poor. He draws near to them.

> *“This poor man called out, and the LORD heard him; He saved him from all his troubles”* (Psalm 34:6).

Also see

> “But I am poor and needy; may the Lord think of me. You are my helper and deliverer; O my God, do not delay” (Psalm 40:17).

> “He raises the poor from the dust and lifts the needy from the dump” (Psalm 113:7).

> “‘The Spirit of the Lord is on Me, because He has anointed Me to preach good news to the poor. He has sent Me to proclaim liberty to the captives and recovery of sight to the blind, to release the oppressed.’” (Luke 4:18).

> “The rich and the poor have this in common: The LORD is Maker of them all” (Proverbs 22:2).

Common self-statements

- God has turned His back on me.
- I am not important to God.
- He prefers people who have more.
- I am on the outside of His blessing.
- I am a disappointment to Him.
- Even God has given up on me.

Common logical errors

- Emotional reasoning: Feeling rejected and concluding that God has rejected me.
- Mind reading: Assuming I know God’s view of me from my circumstances.
- Overgeneralizing: Letting people’s rejection stand for God’s.
- Labeling: Calling myself “rejected.”

Challenging questions

- Who made me feel less because of money, and how has that colored my picture of God?
- What does Scripture say about how God sees the poor?

- How did Jesus treat people who had little?
- What does “Maker of them all” say about my worth?
- When have I sensed God near me even in a hard time?
- What would change if I believed God draws near to me now?

Truth summary

> God has not rejected me. He hears the poor, helps the needy, and lifts them up. I am His, made in His image and loved. My circumstances do not change how close He is.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Poverty
- God, All Loving
- Loneliness
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Refuge/Safety

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Suffering

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God’s companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

The God Who Stays — Matthew West
God’s faithful presence challenges the expectation of rejection and abandonment.

He Knows — Jeremy Camp
Jesus understands suffering and invites people to bring their burdens to Him.

Softly and Tenderly — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
This older hymn pictures Christ’s gracious invitation to return rather than hide in shame.

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Being poor means God has rejected me"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Being poor means God has rejected me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who made me feel less because of money?
- ☐ How does God see the poor?
- ☐ How did Jesus treat those with little?
- ☐ When have I sensed God near?
- ☐ What does being His mean?
- ☐ Where can I find a welcoming community?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God hears the poor.
- ☐ He is my helper and deliverer.
- ☐ He raises the poor from the dust.
- ☐ Jesus came with good news for the poor.
- ☐ The Lord is Maker of us all.
- ☐ I am accepted, not rejected.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 34:6
  "This poor man called out, and the LORD heard him; He saved him from all his troubles."
- ☐ Psalm 113:7
  "He raises the poor from the dust and lifts the needy from the dump."
- ☐ Luke 4:18
  "'The Spirit of the Lord is on Me, because He has anointed Me to preach good news to the poor. He has sent Me to proclaim liberty to the captives and recovery of sight to the blind, to release the oppressed.'"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Heard and held: Each day, write one moment you sensed God near, however small.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Psalm 34:6 becomes: "Sarah can write: "The Lord heard this poor man and saved him, and He hears me.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Poverty" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- ☐ Name who made you feel less. Write the people or places and forgive them as you are able.
- ☐ Read Psalm 34:6 and 113:7. Say them aloud.
- ☐ Find a welcoming community. Look for a church or group that treats everyone as equals.
- ☐ Tell God how you feel. Pray honestly about rejection and ask Him to show His nearness.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Being poor means God has rejected me": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	God drew near
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Being poor means God has rejected me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You hear the poor and lift the needy. When I feel rejected, remind me that I am Yours. Draw near to me, and heal the hurts that people have caused. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #49 · PROSPERITY AND BLESSING

“God only blesses people who succeed.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Cultures that celebrate achievement can seep into our picture of God. Churches may spotlight winners and testimonies of success, while those who struggle go unnoticed. Over time, we learn that God’s favor is for the accomplished, and we hide our failures to stay in His good graces.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, “God chose the foolish things of the world to shame the wise; God chose the weak things of the world to shame the strong. He chose the lowly and despised things of the world.” Jesus said, “Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.” The psalmist says, “Better is the little of the righteous than the abundance of many who are wicked.” To Paul, God said, “My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.” God’s blessing is not reserved for winners.

> *“But God chose the foolish things of the world to shame the wise; God chose the weak things of the world to shame the strong. He chose the lowly and despised things of the world, and the things that are not, to nullify the things that are”* (1 Corinthians 1:27–28).

Also see

> “‘Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.’” (Matthew 5:3).

> “Better is the little of the righteous than the abundance of many who are wicked” (Psalm 37:16).

> “But He said to me, ‘My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.’ Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me” (2 Corinthians 12:9).

> “‘The Spirit of the Lord is on Me, because He has anointed Me to preach good news to the poor. He has sent Me to proclaim liberty to the captives and recovery of sight to the blind, to release the oppressed.’” (Luke 4:18).

Common self-statements

- I have to succeed for God to bless me.
- Failure puts me outside His favor.
- God favors the capable.
- I must hide my struggles.
- I have not earned His blessing.
- Only winners get blessed.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either a success or outside God’s blessing.
- Should statements: Insisting that I must achieve to deserve blessing.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling like a failure and concluding God is distant.
- Social comparison: Measuring my blessing against others’ achievements.

Challenging questions

- Where did I learn that blessing is tied to success?
- Whom did God choose in the Bible, and were they successful by the world's standards?
- What does Jesus say about the poor in spirit?
- What blessings have I received that I did not earn?
- What would it mean for God's power to be perfected in my weakness?
- Who could I be honest with about a struggle?

Truth summary

> God's blessing is grace, not a reward for success. He often chooses the weak and lowly. I can bring my struggles to Him, knowing His power is made perfect in weakness.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grace
- Weakness
- Blessings
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Humility

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Pride

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ's final restoration.

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Greater — MercyMe
God's presence and grace challenge shame and the need to win everyone's approval.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "God only blesses people who succeed"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"God only blesses people who succeed." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Where did I learn blessing needs success?
- ☐ Whom does God choose?
- ☐ What blessings were unearned?
- ☐ What does weakness do for His power?
- ☐ Who can I be honest with?
- ☐ Whom can I encourage?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God's blessing is grace.
- ☐ He chooses the weak and lowly.
- ☐ Blessed are the poor in spirit.
- ☐ Better is little with righteousness.
- ☐ His power is perfected in weakness.
- ☐ I do not have to succeed to be loved.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 1 Corinthians 1:27–28

  "But God chose the foolish things of the world to shame the wise; God chose the weak things of the world to shame the strong. He chose the lowly and despised things of the world, and the things that are not, to nullify the things that are."

- ☐ Matthew 5:3

  "'Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.'"

- ☐ 2 Corinthians 12:9

  "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me."

A verse I found myself: _____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Grace received: Each day, write one blessing you received that you did not earn.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 2 Corinthians 12:9 becomes: "Sarah can write: "His grace is sufficient for me, and His power is perfected in my weakness.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Grace" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- ☐ List unearned blessings. Write ten gifts you did not work for.
- ☐ Be honest with one person. Share a struggle with a trusted friend.
- ☐ Read 2 Corinthians 12:9. Write it on a card and carry it.
- ☐ Celebrate someone else. Encourage a person who is struggling instead of a winner.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "God only blesses people who succeed": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Grace received
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~God only blesses people who succeed.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You choose the weak and the lowly. Free me from performing for Your favor. Let Your grace be sufficient and Your power be seen in my weakness. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #50 · PROSPERITY AND BLESSING

“Struggling financially means I'm out of God's will.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Many believers equate being in God’s will with everything falling into place. When a job ends or money gets tight, they wonder if they missed a turn. A past decision, such as a career move, a risky purchase, or an act of disobedience, can seem to be the cause, and the worry becomes a constant question: “Did I get out of God’s will?”

What Scripture teaches

Scripture says, “I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans to prosper you and not to harm you, to give you a future and a hope.” Proverbs says, “A man’s heart plans his course, but the LORD determines his steps.” The psalmist says, “The steps of a man are ordered by the LORD… Though he falls, he will not be overwhelmed, for the LORD is holding his hand.” Paul, who was in God’s will, was shipwrecked, imprisoned, and often in need. Hardship does not prove we have wandered off the path.

> *“The steps of a man are ordered by the LORD who takes delight in his journey. Though he falls, he will not be overwhelmed, for the LORD is holding his hand”* (Psalm 37:23–24).

Also see

> “For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans to prosper you and not to harm you, to give you a future and a hope” (Jeremiah 29:11).

> “A man’s heart plans his course, but the LORD determines his steps” (Proverbs 16:9).

> “And we know that God works all things together for the good of those who love Him, who are called according to His purpose” (Romans 8:28).

> “Though the fig tree does not bud and no fruit is on the vines, though the olive crop fails and the fields produce no food, though the sheep are cut off from the fold and no cattle are in the stalls, yet I will exult in the LORD; I will rejoice in the God of my salvation!” (Habakkuk 3:17–18).

Common self-statements

- I must have missed God’s direction.
- This is what happens when I step out of His will.
- If I were in His will, things would be smoother.
- I made a wrong turn and ruined everything.
- God is not guiding me anymore.
- I cannot trust my own decisions.

Common logical errors

- Hindsight bias: Judging past decisions by results I could not know.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either perfectly in God’s will or out of it.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling lost and concluding that I am out of His will.
- Personalization: Blaming myself for circumstances with many causes.

Challenging questions

- What exactly do I believe I did that took me out of God's will?
- Did people in the Bible who followed God face hardship? What does that say?
- What does God promise about directing my steps?
- Is there any known disobedience I need to confess, and what does Scripture say about forgiveness?
- What good has God brought out of past hard times?
- What is one next faithful step?

Truth summary

> God orders the steps of those who follow Him, and when I fall, He holds my hand. Hardship does not prove I am out of His will. I can confess any sin, take the next faithful step, and trust Him to work all things for good.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Will of God
- Guidance
- Plans
- Trust
- Guilt/Shame

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Trouble/Hardship
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ's resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Struggling financially means I'm out of God's will"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Struggling financially means I'm out of God's will." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What decision do I fear was wrong?
- ☐ What does Scripture say about God ordering my steps?
- ☐ Is there sin to confess?
- ☐ What good has God brought from hard times?
- ☐ Who can advise me?
- ☐ What is my next faithful step?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ The Lord orders my steps.
- ☐ He holds my hand when I fall.
- ☐ His plans for me are for a future and a hope.
- ☐ Hardship is not proof I am out of His will.
- ☐ He works all things for good.
- ☐ I can take the next faithful step.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 37:23–24
  "The steps of a man are ordered by the LORD who takes delight in his journey. Though he falls, he will not be overwhelmed, for the LORD is holding his hand."
- ☐ Jeremiah 29:11
  "For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans to prosper you and not to harm you, to give you a future and a hope."
- ☐ Proverbs 16:9
  "A man's heart plans his course, but the LORD determines his steps."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

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PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ The next faithful step: Each day, write one faithful step you can take today.
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  For example, Psalm 37:23–24 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Though I fall, the Lord is holding my hand.""
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Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

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- ☐ Write the fear. Describe the decision you fear took you out of God's will.
- ☐ Confess and receive. If there is sin, confess it and receive forgiveness.
- ☐ Seek counsel. Ask a wise friend or pastor for perspective on your next steps.
- ☐ Pray Psalm 37:23–24. Ask Him to order your steps.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Struggling financially means I'm out of God's will": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

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My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Struggling financially means I'm out of God's will.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You hold my hand. Forgive me where I have strayed, and guide me where I am confused. Order my steps, and help me trust that You are with me in hard times. Amen.

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